



BEFORE

On April 3, the Southern capital Richmond fell to Union troops (see [The Fall of Petersburg and Richmond](#)). Confederate hopes now lay in tatters, yet General Robert E. Lee's army still had not yet been defeated.

SHRINKING OPTIONS

The **Army of Northern Virginia's only remaining hope** lay in evading its Union pursuers until it could **join up with General Joseph Johnston's Army of North Carolina**. But Lee's men were outnumbered—25,000 against 125,000 Union troops under General Ulysses S. Grant. They were also exhausted, while the Union forces were buoyed by the prospect of final victory.

RACING TO RAILROADS

To have any chance of making contact with Johnston, Lee would have to **evacuate his troops by rail**. The retreat westward thus became **a desperate race to reach railheads**—a race in which the Union troops had the advantage from the start.

The opening battle of the war, First Bull Run, was fought on land belonging to Wilmer McLean, a sugar broker, who also owned the house in which Lee and Grant signed the surrender.

The single greatest imperative facing General Robert E. Lee after the loss of Petersburg was the need to reestablish supply lines to feed his hungry men. His immediate target was the village of Amelia Court House, which lay on the Richmond and Danville railroad line. There he hoped to find not just ample supplies of food but also a base from which he could evacuate his army by rail south to Danville, Virginia, where Confederate President Jefferson Davis was waiting. From Danville he hoped to effect a rendezvous with General Joseph E. Johnston's Army of North Carolina, which was the only other substantial Confederate army in the field.

Yet his hopes would be sorely dashed. In the confusion of the flight from Petersburg the wrong orders were dispatched, and what the Confederate troops found on arriving at Amelia station was a huge stash of ammunition—worse than useless to the army, as their supply wagons could barely carry the ordnance they already had.

Lost time

Lee knew that his exhausted men could not continue without sustenance, and valuable time was lost while foraging parties